Vendor Discovery, Done Properly

The five proofs to demand from every e-invoicing platform, before your invoice data becomes the tax authority's source of truth.

For CFOs preparing for the French e-invoicing mandate.
Phase 1 go-live: 1 September 2026.

From 1 September 2026, every business in France must be able to receive e-invoices, and grandes entreprises (large enterprises, broadly those with more than 5,000 employees) and entreprises de taille intermédiaire (mid-size enterprises, broadly those with between 250 and 4,999 employees) must issue e-invoices and file e-reporting through a DGFiP-registered Plateforme Agréée (PA). From that date your B2B invoices, their lifecycle statuses and your e-reporting data all flow through your platform to the DGFiP. That makes your platform the custodian of your most sensitive commercial data: every customer, every price, every margin, every dispute.

Every vendor will tell you they are “conforme DGFiP”. Almost none will put it in writing. The rule of vendor discovery is simple: if a compliance claim exists only in a demo or a slide, treat it as unverified. Every claim below should map to a document you can hold, an audit you can read, or an SLA you can enforce. Ask every vendor for all four, then ask for them signed.

A platform security failure here is not an IT incident. It is a business exposure event, visible to the DGFiP and, under the GDPR, to the CNIL.

01

The Security Engagement Review (SER) walkthrough

A Security Engagement Review is where claims meet evidence: an independent penetration test, plus a signed commitment on exactly how your data is handled.

DEMAND THIS EVIDENCE

- An independent penetration test (VAPT) on the platform, with a walkthrough of the latest report: what was found, and what was fixed.
- Testing that recurs (annually or better, and after major releases), not a one-off exercise.
- A signed data-handling commitment: who can access your data, under what roles, with what logging, and how access is revoked.
- Access governed by role-based access control (RBAC), with every API call authenticated by token, not blanket administrator access.
- Willingness to complete your security questionnaire and sit with your infosec team, rather than a redirect to a generic trust page.

Red flag to watch:

A vendor who shares a certificate but will not walk you through the underlying report. A certificate says testing happened; the walkthrough tells you whether they understood the findings.

The Cleartax answer:

Cleartax runs independent third-party VAPT with regular testing and hardening, and independently audited controls. Access is governed by RBAC with granular permissions, every API call is authenticated by token, and data handling follows GDPR-aligned, privacy-by-design controls. The evidence is available in the first meeting, under NDA, with your infosec team in the room.

02

Registration and independent audits

In France, certification is not a nice-to-have; registration is the licence to operate. A platform is only as good as the scope of its certification, the qualification of its hosting, and the independence of its audit. Ask for scope and dates, not logos.

DEMAND THIS EVIDENCE

- Registration as a Plateforme Agréée (PA) on the DGFiP's official registry: the legal licence to transmit invoices and e-reporting data, granted for a three-year term.
- ISO 27001 certification scoped to the e-invoicing and e-reporting platform, on the current 2022 standard.
- SecNumCloud qualification (ANSSI) for the hosting: the French sovereign-cloud standard, immune to extraterritorial law such as the US Cloud Act.
- An independent compliance audit against the DGFiP specifications and EN 16931.
- Native support for the mandated formats (Factur-X, UBL 2.1 and CII), and Peppol interoperability.

The Cleartax answer:

- ClearTax is listed on the DGFiP's official registry as a Plateforme Agréée (PA),
- It holds ISO 27001:2022 and SOC 2, is GDPR compliant, hosts on SecNumCloud 3.2 qualified infrastructure.
- Supports Factur-X, UBL 2.1 and CII under EN 16931 with Peppol interoperability.
- These controls run at scale every day (over 1B e-invoices a year across 5,000+ enterprises in 50+ countries), not maintained only for the audit.

03

The data-residency note

“Hosted in the EU” can mean many things. The questions that matter: where is production, where is failover, and can anything, including backups, ever be reached under a foreign law?

DEMAND THIS EVIDENCE

- Production and disaster recovery both inside the European Economic Area. A French primary with a failover outside the EEA is not data residency.
- Hosting qualified against SecNumCloud, so no backup or replica is ever reachable under an extraterritorial law such as the US Cloud Act.
- Contractual recovery-time and recovery-point objectives, committed rather than aspirational.
- Backups and replication that stay in region, never quietly transiting a non-EEA region.

The Cleartax answer:

- Cleartax hosts on S3NS Cloud in France (SecNumCloud 3.2 qualified), multi-availability-zone, with local data residency.
- Production stays on French soil under a sovereign-cloud standard, so a provider-level issue never becomes your compliance failure and no invoice data leaves the jurisdiction.
- Delivered through a local Europe entity, aligned with the GDPR.

04

The SLA sheet

An SLA without service credits is a wish. Ask every vendor to put numbers, and consequences, on paper. Under the French mandate your platform's reliability is your penalty exposure: a missed e-invoice carries a statutory penalty of €50 per invoice (capped at €15,000 a year under Art. 1737 III CGI), and a missed e-reporting transmission €500 per transmission (also capped at €15,000 a year under Art. 1788 D CGI).

The Cleartax answer:

- Cleartax operates at 99.29% to 100% uptime, generates a 5 to 10 line-item invoice in 200 to 300 ms, and scales to 10,000 e-invoices a second with auto-scaling.
- Support is 24x7 with a dedicated local Customer Success Manager, in-house tax experts, and a three-tier escalation matrix agreed at implementation.
- Delivery is handled by 75+ engineers and consultants with 2,500+ integrations behind them, and Recon AI reconciles your ERP against reported e-invoice data daily to catch gaps before they become notices.

05

The continuity commitment

The French mandate is the first mile, not the destination. Under VAT in the Digital Age (ViDA), adopted in March 2025, mandatory B2B e-invoicing and near-real-time Digital Reporting Requirements apply to intra-EU transactions from 1 July 2030. Because France's regime postdates 2024, it is not grandfathered: your cross-border flows must align to the EU standard, not stand still. The proof that matters is not a promise about 2030. It is evidence that the platform has already absorbed mandate change without forcing its customers to re-implement.

DEMAND THIS EVIDENCE

- A live track record in comparable clearance or CTC mandates delivered in the last 24 months, with named tax authorities and named go-lives, not a roadmap slide.
- A published roadmap covering the EN 16931 modernisation for B2B (adopted February 2026) and the ViDA DRR transition to July 2030, with committed dates.
- A contractual commitment that future regulatory change, whether new fields, formats, lifecycle statuses, or the ViDA DRR transition itself, is delivered as a platform upgrade, not a chargeable re-implementation project or a fresh integration.
- Continuity terms on paper: notice periods, migration and exit assistance, and data portability, so a vendor change, or a vendor failure, never strands your compliance.
- A single integration and unified API that extends to new jurisdictions by configuration, so ViDA readiness is a setting to switch on, not a second ERP project.

Red flag to watch:

A vendor whose "ViDA-ready" claim lives only on a slide, or whose price list carries a line item for every future regulatory change. If each new mandate is a new project, you have bought a France-only tool, and one in three companies replace their e-invoicing vendor within a year.

The Cleartax answer:

- Cleartax runs on a single global platform that already lives in 50+ countries, generating over 1B e-invoices a year.
- With regulator-level standing across multiple live mandates, we are advisor to ZATCA on the Saudi Phase-1 pilot and an approved provider for Phase-II, listed on the DGFiP Plateforme Agréée registry in France, on Belgium's FPS Finance portal and Germany's VeR, approved by the UAE's FTA and Oman's OTA, licensed to generate e-invoices on behalf of the Indian tax authority, and a registered Peppol Access Point.
- New mandates and amendments arrive as configuration and upgrades on one unified API, delivered as an update rather than a rebuild, so the ViDA DRR transition in 2030 is a switch to turn on, not a second implementation. That is continuity you can hold to in the contract, not just hear in the demo.

The bottom line for CFOs

Security and trust are not evaluated in a demo. They are evaluated in documents: a penetration test you can read, a registration with scope and dates, a residency note with no asterisks, and an SLA with credits attached. Cleartax will hand you all four, signed. Ask every other vendor to do the same.

Talk to a ClearTax expert to see the evidence, under NDA →